National
Qualifications
2025

X824/76/11

English
Reading for Understanding, Analysis and Evaluation — Text

WEDNESDAY, 7 MAY
9:00 AM – 10:30 AM

Total marks — 30

Read the passages carefully and then attempt ALL questions, which are printed on a separate sheet.

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The following two passages discuss the street artist Banksy.

Passage 1

Read the passage below and attempt questions 1 to 8.

In the first passage, Paul Gough writes a profile of the street artist Banksy.

Prankster, activist, painter: Banksy is the world's most famous street artist. For many years, the question of Banksy's identity has been as intriguing to the press and public as the unconventional quality of his work or the price that dealers, celebrities and other wealthy fans are prepared to pay for it. One of his greatest triumphs has been his ability to keep his identity cloaked in mystery. Anonymity is, however, less important than the impact of his art, which is more than likely created with a group of collaborators. At least that is what we think we know. These are the known unknowns.

'The New Yorker' magazine describes how Banksy tries to 'ignore the art world . . . and begs it to notice him at the same time'. Banksy has built up a remarkable reputation for his controversial, wittily political interventions. He has painted peace motifs in areas of international conflict; secretly installed an inflatable figure of a political prisoner in Disneyland; and hung hoax artefacts in the greatest museums in the world.

It was no surprise that he chose an aggressive title for his blockbuster show: 'Banksy versus Bristol Museum'. This encouraged hundreds of thousands to queue patiently to enter, possibly for the first time, the grand pillars and marble halls of Bristol Museum. Visitors were greeted by a burnt-out ice cream van, which acted as an information booth for the show. Banksy's work was secreted throughout the labyrinth of rooms, hidden amongst the fossils and the museum's notable collection of Chinese pottery. Most visitors were delighted and invigorated. Not only had Banksy radically re-mixed the permanent art collection but he had produced a show of surprise and humour. There were walls of ingeniously modified paintings and a menagerie of life-sized animated beasts, including a rabbit applying lipstick and a cheetah transformed into a fur coat. There were classical statues laden with Gucci shopping bags; aquariums full of wriggling fish fingers; a full-size policeman clad in riot-gear gently bobbing on a child's rocking horse.

Over 300,000 people flocked to the six-week long event in Bristol. Most had queued for an average of just under three hours. Popular reviews were ecstatic. Visitors from all over the UK, from Europe and beyond spoke enthusiastically about the humour and the trickery, the sarcastic edge, the colourful attack on established ideas.

Through exhibitions and interventions, Banksy shows contempt for traditional art. Many critics disapprove, one describing his artworks as 'one-dimensional jokes without any poetic feeling. Lacking ambiguity or mystery, everything he creates is unengaging.' Some people also have little time for cocky graffiti artists with their mindless scribble and their uncaring vandalism of 'innocent' property. To many citizens, Banksy's work is far from cosy: it is held to be offensive by some, criminal damage by many. Banksy is also criticised by many street artists and graffitists. They regard Banksy's position as heavily, and irreversibly, compromised, because he earns considerable sums from the sale of his work. Commercial success has long been regarded as a mark of failure for a graffiti artist. To his former allies, his subversiveness does rather diminish as his prices rise. A common complaint amongst his peer group is that 'Banksy has ruined graffiti'.

His work has also given rise to a flood of imitators saturating the world with anaemic copies. Not only is their work generally shoddy and uninspired, but their behaviour is considered completely shameful in most graffiti circles. These Banksy wannabes are doing nothing more than pirating the work and stylings of another artist. Banksy's own art on walls and buildings — in the UK, the Middle East, the USA and Europe — has been relentlessly vandalised, ripped off and removed. It can then re-appear in auction rooms or in backstreet sales lots, invariably at stratospheric prices.

More recently, Banksy's global reputation has been enhanced by his ability to create huge art

spectacles. In Bethlehem, he brought together the work of a diverse group of important artists to revitalise tourism in the troubled town. This exhibition raised a significant sum for charitable causes. A few years later, Banksy staged his largest-scale extravaganza, 'Dismaland', which featured over 58 artists from 17 countries. A satire on theme parks, 'Dismaland' attracted some 150,000 paying customers, to wander the installations of a 'family theme park unsuitable for children'.

Notoriously mysterious, darkly humorous, Banksy is now a global phenomenon. He remains an enigma within the world of art but it is important to remember just what Banksy has achieved. He has been praised as the standard bearer for a new movement in modern art. He has positioned himself at the front of a significant population of street graffiti artists. Thanks to him, a movement of hooded rebels spraying and scrawling on downtown surfaces has crashed through the wall, off the streets and into public consciousness. We should praise Banksy as a creative individual, who uses art to comment on key social issues. We should praise Banksy for constantly pushing at the limitations of his own capability to be both disruptive and meaningful.

Passage 2

Read the passage below and attempt question 9. While reading, you may wish to make notes on the main ideas and/or highlight key points in the passage.

In the second passage, Blane Savage writes about the opening of Banksy's solo exhibition 'Cut & Run' in Glasgow in June 2023.

A new solo exhibition by Banksy, the UK's most famous street artist, has opened in Glasgow at the Gallery of Modern Art. The graffiti artist was drawn to exhibit in Glasgow because of his interest in the symbolism of 'Coneheid', the red traffic cone permanently adorning the head of the Duke of Wellington statue that stands on a plinth outside the gallery. It is, Banksy says, his 'favourite work of art in the UK'. The red traffic cone has historically been placed on Wellington's head by revellers to signify a great night out in the city and is now an iconic part of Glasgow's heritage and marketing. It holds great meaning for Glaswegians in its anti-elitist and anti-establishment message.

The show, 'Cut & Run', spans the artist's career. Banksy has become a major player in the urban and contemporary art world, generating controversy and publicity through his distinctive and creative approach. Popular with the public and highly valued by the art world, Banksy's works convey powerful messages via simple but arresting images. His early unconventional artwork was seen by some as vandalism, but for many others, Banksy is an important counter-culture voice.

The Bristol-based artist is a humanitarian and peace activist, using his wealth to benefit many charitable causes. His artworks raise awareness of political unfairness and challenge social injustices, such as refugee crises, homelessness, global warming, and police violence. These are invariably set within a satirical, witty style that often confronts those in power.

The connection between Banksy and Glasgow runs deep. Both have a history of actively supporting humanitarian causes. Glasgow was the first anti-apartheid city to support Nelson Mandela with a street near the South African consulate renamed to honour him while he was still in prison. It also has a proud reputation for welcoming and defending refugees. Glaswegians are known for their friendliness and irreverent humour which resonates with Banksy's works. The city has actively resourced artists as part of its cultural policy and has been named the UK's top cultural and creative city in a landmark report by the European Commission. The Banksy exhibition will undoubtedly boost Glasgow's reputation as a centre of creative dynamism.

The exhibition starts with a re-creation of his studio space, featuring for the first time the stencils used to create many of his most famous works. It also features 'Banksquiat: Boy and Dog in Stop and Search', Banksy's homage to Jean-Michel Basquiat, the American street artist. A critique of

the controversial nature of police stop-and-search powers, it sold in May 2023 for an astonishing £7,646,000. The infamous shredding mechanism of Banksy's 'Girl with Balloon' is also showcased in the exhibition. In 2018, just after it was purchased at auction for £1 million, the canvas was passed through a secret shredder hidden inside the frame, leaving the bottom half in tatters with only the solitary red balloon untouched. Three years later this iconic artwork was renamed 'Love In The Bin' and auctioned at Sotheby's for a mind-bending £18,852,000. A more recent work, featuring a stencil of a young female gymnast performing a handstand, balancing on a war-torn building, is also on show.

Banksy has been at the forefront of a new art form that started in street art but has matured to include a strategic use of different kinds of media — graffiti, film, performance, digital and social media — all of which have the capacity to maximise the impact of his message in real time with a global reach. It feels significant that Banksy has chosen a gritty, post-industrial Scottish city known for its celebration of the arts for his first show in more than a decade. A shared sense of humour, humanitarian values and a disregard for the establishment mean Banksy's show will be well-received in Glasgow.

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Passage 1 – Article is adapted from 'Banksy: What's the fuss and why does it matter?' by Paul Gough, published in *Humanities, Arts and Social Sciences: It's everyone's business*, Routledge. 2016. ISBN 978-1-138-20555-0.

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